



COLOUR

DOC NO. RL-BRAND-001-COLOR-A REV. A RIPOSTE LABORATORIES

Exact values, every notation, for every token: color-reference.md – generated from brand/tokens.json, so it cannot drift.

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This page is the **reasoning**. It tells you which colour to reach for and, more usefully, which one not to.

SEC.01

1 • THE STORY

An industrial spec sheet printed on bone paper, cut through with jester **mi-parti** – the medieval convention of dividing a garment into contrasting halves. That is the whole palette in one sentence:

- The **document** is ink on bone. Warm, printed, unglamorous, high contrast.
- The **jester** is pink, marigold and teal, applied in bands and blocks, never blended.

The tension between those two is the brand. Lose the ink-on-bone base and you get a children's toy. Lose the accents and you get a tax form.

SEC.02

2 • BASE – INK & PAPER

TOKEN	HEX	RGB	USE
-ink	#1D1A17	29 26 23	All text. All 2px rules. The dark field.
-ink-raised	#241F1B	36 31 27	Panel surface sitting on an ink field
-ink-head	#2B2723	43 39 35	Header fill on an ink field
-ink-line	#5C554C	92 85 76	Dashed dividers on an ink field. Never text.
-bone	#F6F1E7	246 241 231	The paper. Default background.
-bone-dim	#EAE4D6	234 228 214	Recessed paper: sunken panels, spec headers
-white	#FFFFFF	255 255 255	One hero field per site. That is the entire budget.

Why not **#000** on **#fff**? Ink is a warm near-black (hue 30°, 12% saturation) and bone is a warm off-white (hue 40°). Pure black on pure white is the default of every unstyled document on earth; the 4-

degree warm shift is what makes a Riposte page read as **printed matter** rather than **a browser default**. It costs nothing – ink on bone is still 15.39:1.

ink-line is a trap. At #5C554C it hits 2.36:1 against ink. It is a divider colour. If you catch yourself using it for de-emphasised text on a dark field, use `-text-muted` instead – 6.59:1 on ink, and the build fails if any field's muted tier stops clearing AA. The tiers are tabulated in `07-accessibility.md` RL-BRAND-001-A11Y.

SEC.03

3 • ACCENTS – THE MI-PARTI THREE

TOKEN	HEX	HSL	TEXT ON IT
-pink	#F0477D	341 85% 61%	bone
-orange	#FE9A0D	35 99% 52%	ink
-teal	#12B795	168 82% 39%	bone

THEY ROTATE. THIS IS THE RULE PEOPLE BREAK.

The three accents are **equal citizens**. There is no primary. Across any repeated element – cards, steps, section chips, top bars – cycle them in order using `nth-child(3n)` or `nth-child(4n)`:

CSS

```
.partner:nth-child(4n+1) { border-top: 6px solid var(--pink); }
.partner:nth-child(4n+2) { border-top: 6px solid var(--orange); }
.partner:nth-child(4n+3) { border-top: 6px solid var(--teal); }
.partner:nth-child(4n)   { border-top: 6px solid var(--line); } /* ink, then repeat */
```

The 4-cycle (three accents plus ink) is preferred over the 3-cycle for cards, because the ink beat stops the rotation from looking like a rainbow. Use the 3-cycle for small elements – chips, SEC.NN numbers – where the ink beat would read

as a disabled state.

What "no favourite" means in practice: `-accent` exists as a **working** accent for one-off elements (a bullet glyph, an arrow, `.hi` emphasis) where rotation is meaningless. It resolves to pink on bone and flips to teal on ink. That is the only sanctioned asymmetry. It does not license a pink button and a pink heading and a pink underline on the same page.

MARIGOLD IS THE ODD ONE OUT, DELIBERATELY

`-orange` takes **ink** text; the other two take **bone**. This is not an aesthetic whim – it is the contrast maths:

	WITH bone	WITH ink
pink	3.16:1 ×	4.87:1 ✓
orange	1.90:1 ××	8.12:1 ✓✓
teal	2.27:1 ××	6.79:1 ✓

Marigold is far too light to hold bone text at any size. Ink on marigold is the single best-contrasting accent pairing in the system, which is why marigold is the right choice for `.note` callouts and warning states where the text actually has to be read.

SEC.04 4 • DEEP ACCENTS – FOR ACCENTS THAT CARRY SENTENCES

The bright three are **fill colours**. They are correct on chips, spec headers, section bars, `.stat` numbers, and large uppercase display. They are wrong under a paragraph.

When a coloured surface has to hold body copy, or a colour has to **be** text on bone, use the deep variant: identical hue and saturation, lightness dropped until bone clears WCAG AA 4.5:1.

TOKEN	HEX	HSL	BONE ON IT
-pink-deep	#D81150	341 85% 46%	4.53:1 ✓
-orange-deep	#A15E01	35 99% 32%	4.53:1 ✓
-teal-deep	#0C7A63	167 82% 26%	4.69:1 ✓
-teal-ink	#04463A	169 89% 15%	4.24:1 on teal – diagram labels

-teal-deep and -teal-ink predate this addition; they were already in the system for diagram linework. -teal-ink is a **label** colour, not a body colour: on a teal fill it is 4.24:1, which clears AA Large but not AA. Short uppercase labels only – for a sentence on teal, deepen the fill to -teal-deep and put bone on it. -pink-deep and -orange-deep complete the set so all three accents have a text-safe form.

-accent-text resolves to the right one automatically: pink-deep on bone, plain teal on ink (which is already 6.79:1 and needs no deepening), ink on a pink field. Links use it. If you're hand-picking, prefer -accent-text over naming a colour.

SEC.05

5 • FIELDS (THEMES)

A "field" is any element carrying a `data-theme`. They nest — a bone island inside a dark section is `data-theme="light"` — and every pattern in the system reads semantic vars, so they all invert correctly for free.

BONE FIELD — THE DEFAULT

Ink text, ink rules, pink working accent, bone-dim for recessed panels.

INK FIELD — `data-theme="dark"` / `.dark`

```
background  --ink      #1d1a17
panels      --ink-raised #241f1b
headers     --ink-head  #2b2723
text        --bone
2px rules   --bone      ← rules go bone, not grey
1px dashed  --ink-line   #5c554c
accent      --teal       ← flips from pink
```

The accent flips pink → teal. Pink on ink is legal at 4.87:1, but teal reads better on a dark field and keeps it cooler. Do not fight this — if a dark section is coming out pink-dominant, you've hardcoded `-pink` where you should have used `-accent`.

PINK FIELD — `data-theme="pink"` / `.pinkfield`

Full-bleed pink sections (the "Meet Esh" treatment). Everything goes bone: text, rules, dashes. Label fills go `ink` (an ink chip on pink is the strongest mark available). The working accent becomes marigold.

Use this **once per page, maximum**, on a section that earns it. A pink field is a punctuation mark.

SEC.06 6 • APPLYING COLOUR: THE DECISION TREE

Is it text?

- | On bone → --ink. For emphasis, --accent-text (pink-deep).
- | On ink → --bone. For emphasis, --accent (teal).
- | On an accent fill → the fixed rule: bone / INK on marigold / bone.
If it's a full sentence, deepen the fill first.

Is it a line?

- | Structural (2px solid) → --line (ink on bone, bone on ink)
- | Divider (1px dashed) → --line-dashed
- | Card masthead (6px top) → rotating accent
- | Callout spine (8px left) → marigold for notes, pink for pull quotes

Is it a fill?

- | Recessed panel → --bone-dim (light) / --ink-raised (dark)
- | Chip / label → --label-fill (ink, or teal on a dark field)
- | Category / rotation → the accent rotation, in order
- | Full-bleed section → ink field or pink field. Never a marigold or teal field.

Is it a state?

- | Success / pass → --ok (teal) ✓
- | Warning / caution → --warn (marigold) !
- | Error / fail → --danger (pink) ×
- | Focus → --focus-ring (pink on bone, teal on ink), 3px, 2px offset

Note on states: the semantic state colours reuse the accents rather than introducing a red/amber/green set. This is deliberate – a fourth colour family would break the mi-parti. Pink reads as failure well enough at 4.87:1 on ink, and the glyph (✓ ! ×) carries the meaning for anyone who can't distinguish them.

SEC.07

7 • PROPORTION

Roughly, on a well-balanced page:

bone / ink base	~85%	
accent fills & bars	~12%	
white hero field	~3%	(or 0% – most pages don't have one)

If accents are above ~20% of the visual field, you've made a poster, not a document. The bands (`.checker`, `.harlequin`, `.triband`) are **strips** – 26px, 38px, and a footer cell. They are never large fields. That constraint is what keeps the accents feeling expensive.

SEC.08

8 • FORBIDDEN

- ▶ **Gradients** – except the three functional patterns (`-checker`, `-harlequin`, `-triband`), which are hard-stop conic/linear gradients, not blends.
- ▶ **Opacity on colour to make a tint.** `rgba(240,71,125,.2)` is not in the system. If you need a lighter pink, you need `bone-dim` or a `-pink-deep` outline instead. The exception is opacity on **text** for de-emphasis (`.dim` at `.65`), which is fine.
- ▶ **A fourth accent.** There are three. Adding purple because a chart needs a fifth series is how design systems die – see `dataviz` RL-BRAND-001-PAT for the sanctioned way to get more categories.
- ▶ **Pure black or pure white text.** Ink and bone, always.
- ▶ **Colour as the only signal.** Every state pairs with a glyph.

9 • ACCESSIBILITY SUMMARY

Full matrix in `color-reference.md`^{RL-BRAND-001-COLOR-REFERENCE}; the reasoning is in `07-accessibility.md`^{RL-BRAND-001-A11Y}.

Safe for body copy: ink on bone (15.39), bone on ink (15.39), ink on marigold (8.12), ink on teal (6.79), ink on pink (4.87), bone on any `-deep` accent (4.5+).

Display and chrome only: bone on pink (3.16), pink on bone (3.16), teal-ink on teal (4.24).

Never text: bone on marigold (1.90), bone on teal (2.27), marigold on bone (1.90), teal on bone (2.27), `ink-line` on ink (2.36).

The last group is the surprising one: **marigold and teal cannot be text on bone**. If you want a teal heading on a bone page, it must be `-teal-deep`. This is the single most common way to break accessibility in this system.

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